

INDIA PICTURE

PHASE 2: 1992-2014

THE THAW

During Prime Minister Narasimha Rao's tenure, India agreed to establish full-fledged diplomatic relations with Israel in 1992. Apart from trade in agriculture and petroleum products, defence ties blossomed but remained largely under wraps. India continues to support the Palestinian cause and its right to self-determination and supports UN resolutions favouring it

2014-2023

RED HOT

Under Prime Minister Narendra Modi's rule, India raised relations with Israel to the political and strategic level. Relations with Israel were de-hyphenated from Palestine. High-level bilateral visits to Palestine; in 2017, Modi became the first Indian PM to visit Israel. He paid a separate visit to the West Bank in 2018 to meet with Palestinian Authority chairman Mahmoud Abbas



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by building a 60-km-long border wall. Israel permits only three functional border crossings, prompting former British premier David Cameron to call Gaza "an open-air prison". Many experts see Hamas's attack as an attempt to win support among the entire Palestinian population in Israel and replace Fatah as the most powerful representative of the struggle for an independent homeland.

Another major trigger has been the return of Netanyahu as prime minister in November 2022 with the help of two ultra-right-wing parties that had vowed to crush the Palestinian resistance. The air darkened when the Netanyahu government announced that it was going to substantially increase Israeli settlements in the West Bank every year. Israel has always had a "mowing the lawn" policy towards Palestinian groups. It involves periodically defanging and decimating the capability of the Fatah and Hamas military leadership. In recent years, though, the policy seems to have been ineffective in controlling Hamas, which has now demonstrated that it retains the firepower to launch major assaults.

THE SETBACKS FOR ISRAEL

What remains astounding is the laxity of the Israeli defence, intelligence and security apparatus that seemed to have no inkling of the Hamas's plans to launch such a massive attack. Israel had in the past few decades built up a fearsome reputation about its ability to defend itself and launch pre-emptive strikes against groups antagonistic to its interests, such as Hamas. This includes the so-called Iron Dome, a network of radars that detect incoming rockets to Israel and a command-and-control system capable of destroying them in mid-air before they can inflict any damage. That Hamas was able to amass weaponry that could fire thousands of rockets, many of which penetrated the Dome, exposed Israel's hubris and actual vulnerability. Meanwhile, with no Israeli party able to garner a majority on its own in the recent past, successive coalition governments seemed to have weakened not just its political and democratic structure but its security apparatus too. Hamas has exploited this relative complacency and the widening cracks in Israel's defence mechanism.

By executing the massive terror attacks across Israeli cities and settlements, Hamas has achieved multiple objectives. The immediate one is that it has put a pause on the growing rapprochement between Israel and the rest of the Arab world, particularly the Saudis. Experts say that if the war widens and if Palestinian casualties mount in a ground offensive, Israel's relations with the Arab world will go back into the deep freeze for a while. As a former Indian ambassador to Israel puts it, "It has brought the issue of Palestine to the centre stage again. It will be very difficult for major Arab countries to have truck with Israel and brush the Palestinian issue under the carpet as they were about to do." Hamas has also broken the myth of Israeli invincibility and put the PA in the shadow when it comes to fighting for Palestinian rights. As another expert says, "To be frank, these kinds of acts are looked upon as heroic and create positive sentiment across the Arab world." Hamas may find it difficult, though, to win over the West Bank, as in addition to the lack of physical connectivity, there are major ideological and political differences between the two populations. Also, if Hamas proceeds to execute the 100-odd hostages it has taken, it will do immense damage to the Palestinian cause.

The geopolitical impact of the ongoing civil war in Israel can scarcely be underestimated. Even though Iran denies any involvement in the Hamas strikes, it is positioning itself as the captain of the Muslim world and capable of taking on the West. The Saudis have always believed that they were the natural leaders of the Sunni-dominated Islamic world, given their kingdom's prosperity and unique status as the custodian of the two holy mosques. What is galling for them is that the